



ARE WE ANY SAFER?

From beefing up intelligence to upgrading security forces to thwart terror strikes and respond swiftly, INDIA TODAY reviews the progress on the agenda for action

On 26 November last year, everything that could go wrong went wrong in Mumbai. A batch of well-trained, highly motivated terrorists just sailed in and for almost three days held the nation's commercial capital hostage. It was the most brazen act of terror since the attack on Parliament in 2001 and exposed just how dysfunctional India's security and intelligence apparatus was. Whether it was the lack of intelligence, a bungling city police, delayed response by anti-terrorist forces or dithering politicians, the systemic failure was apparent. Soon after 26/11, the INDIA TODAY group had declared a war on terror to highlight the deficiencies and also laid out an agenda for action. It called for a total revamp. One year after Mumbai's horror, is India any safer? Have our porous coastlines been secured? Is our intelligence up to scratch? Is the average constable better equipped and trained to respond to sudden, overwhelming terror? Have the elite forces been overhauled? Most important, has the political leadership of our country seen the light at the end of this tunnel of terror? Our editorial team fanned out to assess just how much had been done. The findings:

■ NSG

GETTING THERE

Four hubs are up, but force not fully equipped

The Home Ministry has stepped in with NSG hubs in Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai and Hyderabad, each with 240 commandos to fight terrorists. But basic issues are yet to be addressed. In the 60 hours of 26/11, the NSG fought through the dark smoke-filled mazes in the Taj and Oberoi hotels and Nariman House battling a critical shortage of specialised equipment. It was as though their equipment clock had stopped in 1984—the year they were raised. A year after India's worst terror strike, the clock continues to remain still for the NSG. A host of specialised equipment, ranging from helmets with integrated communication sets and lightweight bulletproof vests are still in the pipeline. Why is this necessary? Special forces are compact, highly trained and use equipment that is generations ahead of what the terrorists can field. This is necessary to

WHAT'S DONE

- New NSG hubs in four cities created
- Manpower for NSG increased
- Force allowed to requisition civil aircraft in times of emergency

WHAT'S NOT

- No new specialised anti-terror equipment like night vision devices and weapon sights procured
- Troopers not equipped with lightweight bullet-proof jackets and helmets for protection
- Helicopters not provided for rapid response within cities

Rs 2,000 CRORE IS BEING SPENT BY THE NSG ON BUYING LAND AND ERECTING BUILDINGS.

240 COMMANDOS MAN EACH OF THE NSG HUBS IN MUMBAI, KOLKATA, CHENNAI AND HYDERABAD.



COMMANDOS AT A DISPLAY